

The Longer Race

*Why the race worth running is the next thousand years, not the next quarter —
run together, not sprinted alone*

Working draft v0.4 · June 22, 2026

The objection worth taking seriously

Every proposal to build something in common runs into the same objection, and it deserves a real answer rather than a slogan. The objection is that competition is what makes an economy work — that the rivalry of firms chasing profit is the engine that lowered prices, raised wages, and filled the shelves, and that anything built on “collaboration” is soft-headed, a charity that will be out-produced by the hard discipline of the market. People who say this are not wrong about the past. Competition under capitalism really did raise the standard of living for enormous numbers of people, over a long time, and any honest case for a different internet has to begin by admitting it.

So this essay does not argue that competition is bad, or that we should abolish it, or that prices are a trick. It argues something more specific, and harder to wave away: that a collaborative system can do everything a competitive one can — *including run a competition whenever competition is the better tool* — and can do more besides, and can share the result more evenly. Not a softer economy. A larger one, more fairly held.

Two systems, and the one we’re not going back to

Start with the choice we are usually offered. On one side, communism and socialism, where wealth is shared, but shared by *force*. The state takes and redistributes; the sharing is not chosen, it is enforced. On the other side, capitalism, whose real improvement was to remove that coercion: it left the getting and the giving to individuals, acting freely. Whatever else divides these systems — and people have argued it to exhaustion, more ably than I can here — that is the line that matters for us. We are not proposing to step back across it. Coerced sharing is not the model. Whatever we build has to be *voluntary*, or it is not worth building.

But removing coercion did not make capitalism perfect, and pretending otherwise is how the conversation usually goes wrong. There is a flaw, and naming it precisely is where the argument starts.

The flaw is not inequality. It is the leash.

People who worry about capitalism usually point to inequality — the gap between what the top earns and what the bottom earns. But a gap, by itself, is not the deepest problem. Two people can earn very different amounts and still stand as equals, each free, neither holding power over the other. Inequality of *income* is a gap. What should worry us more is inequality of a different kind: the steady drift toward a world in which a growing number of people are *in debt* to a shrinking

number of people.

Debt is not just a number. A debt is a *leash*. It gives one party a standing claim on another's future work — your time, years out, already owed before you have lived it. When more and more people are on the leash and fewer and fewer hold the other end, something has gone wrong that no rise in the average standard of living repairs. The economists Atif Mian and Amir Sufi have traced¹ how much of modern economic pain runs through exactly this channel: it is the *concentration of debt*, not income alone, that decides who absorbs the losses when things go bad, and it is the debtors, every time. The power that one set of people comes to hold over another through debt is the thing a better system should set out to reverse.

Reverse it, that is, *by consent* — not by seizing and redistributing, but by building an economy whose ordinary workings spread ownership outward instead of gathering it in. Which brings us to how.

The bigger circle

Here is the central idea, and it is simpler than it sounds. **A collaborative system can choose to hold a competition. A competition cannot choose to collaborate.**

Think about what that means. If a group of people working toward a goal decide that the best way to get there is to compete — to race, to let rivals push each other, to reward whoever does best — they can simply do that. The competition runs *inside* the collaboration, as a tool the group picked up because it worked. But go the other way: take a pure competition, a set of rivals each out only for themselves, and there is no neutral ground on which they can decide to collaborate. The moment they coordinate, the competition is no longer pure. Collaboration is the bigger circle; it can draw competition inside it. Competition is the smaller one; it cannot contain the whole.

This is what dissolves the objection we started with. We do not have to give up what competition is good at. A collaborative internet keeps **as much friendly competition, and as much honest pricing, as it takes to get at least the full benefit a competitive market would have produced.** Where rivalry sharpens the work, we let people compete. Where prices carry information that no planner could gather — and they do; this is the one thing the defenders of markets are most right about — we keep the prices. We give up *none* of competition's efficiency. We simply refuse to stop there.

Because there is a second kind of problem, where stopping at competition leaves real value on the floor.

Two races

Picture a track, and a group of runners with a shared goal. Two different goals, actually, and the right way to organize the runners depends entirely on which goal it is.

Suppose the goal is to get *every* runner across the finish line in the shortest possible time, and each runner has to cover the distance on their own legs. Then a friendly race is the best thing you can do. Everyone starts together, and the rivalry pulls each of them faster than they would have run alone — pushing one another, cheering one another on, every personal best lifting the group's time. This is competition at its finest, and a collaborative system, faced with this goal, would *choose* exactly this. There is no tension here at all.

Now change the goal. Suppose what you want is the *greatest total distance covered* in a fixed

amount of time, and runners are allowed to tag in and out. The best arrangement is no longer a race. It is a *relay*: your fastest runner runs flat out while the others rest, then hands off to the next, who runs while the first recovers — each doing what they do best, no one wasting strength on ground a fresher runner could cover faster. The total distance a relay covers will beat what you would get by making every runner grind out the whole course alone. And a purely competitive rule — *everyone runs the entire distance by themselves* — produces exactly that worse result. It forces duplication: ten runners each running the same miles, when the miles only needed running once.

This is one of the oldest findings in economics, dressed in running shoes. Adam Smith called it the division of labor; David Ricardo called it comparative advantage²; the point in both is that pooling effort and letting each person do what they are best at produces more than everyone doing everything separately. The relay is that idea in motion. And the lesson of the two races is the lesson of the bigger circle: a collaborative system can run whichever race the problem calls for, while a competitive system is stuck running the second one as if it were the first — making everyone cover the whole distance alone, and calling the wasted effort “competition.”

So the real question becomes: which kind of race is the internet?

Sandwiches and songs

Almost everything valuable on the internet is the second kind of race, and to see why, it helps to sort the world’s goods into two piles.

Some things get *used up* when they are shared. A sandwich is the clearest case: if I eat half, there is half as much for you. Land, fuel, a seat on a train — these are *rival* goods, and competition over them makes sense, because there genuinely is not enough to go around. Most of what the old economy fought over was this kind of thing.

But other things do *not* get used up when shared. A song does not become quieter because a million people hear it. A map does not wear out because everyone uses it. A piece of software, a fact, a dataset, a connected network — I can use these without leaving any less for you. Economists call them *non-rival* goods, and they have a strange and wonderful property: sharing them is not a sacrifice, it is the *efficient* thing to do. To wall off a non-rival good — to lock a song or a map or a dataset behind a fence so only a few can reach it — destroys value for no reason at all, because letting more people use it costs nothing and helps everyone.

Here is the thing the modern internet would rather you not notice: its core goods are almost *all* non-rival. Data, software, knowledge, the network itself — none of it gets used up. And yet the whole industry is built on fencing these things off and charging for access, one walled garden competing with the next. The economists Charles Jones and Christopher Tonetti studied data³ in particular and reached the conclusion the larger picture implies: because data is non-rival, the arrangement that creates the most value is for it to be *widely used*, and the real question is not how to ration it but *who gets to control it*. Hoarding it behind walls leaves enormous value uncreated.

We do not have to guess whether collaboration can produce non-rival goods at world scale, because it already has. Linux — the operating system running most of the internet’s servers and, through Android, most of the world’s phones — was built by people collaborating, not by a single firm competing. Wikipedia out-produced every commercial encyclopedia that came before it.⁴ These are not charities; they are among the most-used things humans have ever made, and they were made by the bigger circle. And the old fear that anything held in common must collapse into neglect, the “tragedy of the commons”⁵, was answered decades ago by the political economist

Elinor Ostrom, who won a Nobel Prize⁶ for documenting, case after real-world case, communities that govern shared resources *sustainably and by choice*. A commons does not have to fall apart. It has to be *designed* well.

What we keep, and what we change

So the argument is not that collaboration always beats competition. Said that baldly, it would be false, and you would be right to distrust it. Competition does something real: it tests ideas, rewards the ones that work, and, through prices, gathers up scattered knowledge that no central authority could ever assemble. The thinker who saw this most clearly, Friedrich Hayek, made it the heart⁷ of his case against central planning, and he was right to. It is *because* he was right that a collaborative internet must be voluntary and decentralized — many communities, real prices, genuine rivalry — and never a single planner deciding from the center.

What changes, then, is not whether we compete. It is two things. First, we *choose the right race for each problem* — friendly competition where that produces the most, collaboration where that does — rather than forcing everything through competition out of habit. And second, and most important: **the rewards are shared evenly**. The value the network creates flows back to the people who make it up, instead of pooling in the hands of whoever owns the walls.

Put those together and you get the actual claim of this essay, which is more careful, and stronger, than “collaboration wins”:

*A collaborative internet produces **at least as much** real value as a competitive one — because it can run a competition wherever competition is best — and **more** wherever collaboration is best, and it shares that value **far more evenly**.*

An economist would call that *dominance*: a choice at least as good as the alternative in every case, and better in some. We are not asking anyone to accept less so that things can be fairer. We are saying the fairer arrangement also makes *more*, and the only reason it does not exist already is that the people who own the walls have no reason to tear them down.

The longer race

There is a deeper reason to choose all of this, underneath the economics, and it comes down to *which race you think you are running*.

The companies that own the internet today are built to win the next quarter — the next earnings call, the next funding round, the next product cycle. And a quarter is a sprint: you win it by outrunning whoever happens to be beside you, right now, over a short stretch of track. None of that is wrong on its own terms. But it is the wrong race. The internet is not a quarter-long thing. It is where a civilization will think and talk and trade and remember — not for a few years but for centuries, the public square and the printing press and the marketplace of an entire age at once. The game worth optimizing for is the next *thousand years*, not the next quarter.

And you do not win a thousand-year race by sprinting against the people next to you. This is not a change of heart about competition — we have already seen that a friendly sprint is sometimes the fastest way to cover a particular stretch, and we keep it exactly where it earns its place. It is the

refusal of one specific mistake: treating the whole internet as a short dash to be won by outrunning your neighbor, when it is really a thousand-year endurance run — the kind that is won the way a relay is won, by everyone willing to run taking their turn, handing off, covering for one another, and going far further together than the fastest sprinter ever goes alone.

That is the longer race. It is the one we are actually in, whether we admit it or not, and it is the one a collaborative internet is built to win — not by leaving competition behind, but by putting it in the service of a horizon long enough to be worth the running.

The internet we'd actually run together

Strip away the theory and here is what it means for an ordinary person. On today's internet you generate enormous value — your data, your attention, your contributions, the network of people you bring with you — and almost none of it flows back to you. It collects instead on the far side of a wall, in the accounts of a handful of companies, and the gap between what you make and what you keep is the modern version of the leash. A collaborative internet is simply one that stops pretending the walls have to be there. It keeps the competition that makes things good. It keeps the prices that keep things honest. It adds collaboration wherever collaboration makes more. And then it does the one thing the walls were built to prevent: it lets the value land on the people who created it.

That is not a smaller economy than the one we have. It is a bigger one — at least as much made, and far more evenly held. The only thing it asks us to give up is the habit of running every race alone.

SOURCES & NOTES

1. Atif Mian and Amir Sufi, *House of Debt* (University of Chicago Press, 2014), tracing how the *concentration of debt*, not income inequality alone, decides who bears the losses in a downturn. ↩
2. Adam Smith, *An Inquiry into the Nature and Causes of the Wealth of Nations* (1776), Book I, on the division of labor; and David Ricardo, *On the Principles of Political Economy and Taxation* (1817), ch. 7, on comparative advantage. ↩
3. Charles I. Jones and Christopher Tonetti, “Nonrivalry and the Economics of Data,” *American Economic Review* 110, no. 9 (2020): because data is non-rival, the value-maximizing arrangement is wide use, and the real question is who controls it. <https://www.aeaweb.org/articles?id=10.1257/aer.20191330> ↩
4. That large-scale value can be produced by open collaboration rather than competing firms, “commons-based peer production”, is documented in Yochai Benkler, *The Wealth of Networks* (Yale University Press, 2006). ↩
5. The phrase is from Garrett Hardin, “The Tragedy of the Commons,” *Science* 162 (1968) — whose pessimism Ostrom’s later fieldwork substantially answered. ↩
6. Elinor Ostrom, *Governing the Commons* (Cambridge University Press, 1990), which documented durable, self-governing commons and earned her the 2009 Nobel Prize in Economic Sciences. ↩
7. Friedrich A. Hayek, “The Use of Knowledge in Society,” *American Economic Review* 35, no. 4 (1945) — the classic argument that prices carry dispersed knowledge no central planner could assemble. ↩